**THE BYPOLL RESULTS SHOW THAT A CULTURE OF DEFECTION WILL NOT WORK IN HIMACHAL PRADESH**

Congress, Vikramaditya Singh, had already plummeted after his defeat in the Lok Sabha polls from Mandi when out of the 17 assembly segments, he could muster leads in only Lahaul & Spiti, Karsog, Rampur and Kinnaur. During the February crisis, Vikramaditya had resigned from the cabinet, but was persuaded to stay on by the Congress high command.

This in no way offers a carte blanche to Sukhu—it was his working style that first engendered widespread disaffection within the Congress, offering scope to engineer mutiny. Yet the bypolls hold out one lesson—a culture of defections won't work in Himachal. It also exposed a tactical flaw in the BJP—they ought to have waited for the fate of the six rebels before inducting the independents. Now, with a strengthened Sukhu, disgruntled Congress legislators are being extra cautious.

But Sukhu can't rest easy. If the Shimla High Court disqualifies the six Congress MLAs who were appointed chief parliamentary secretaries in 2023—in an 'office of profit' case pending before it—the Congress is in for another convulsion. The BJP would certainly pray for that to happen. ■

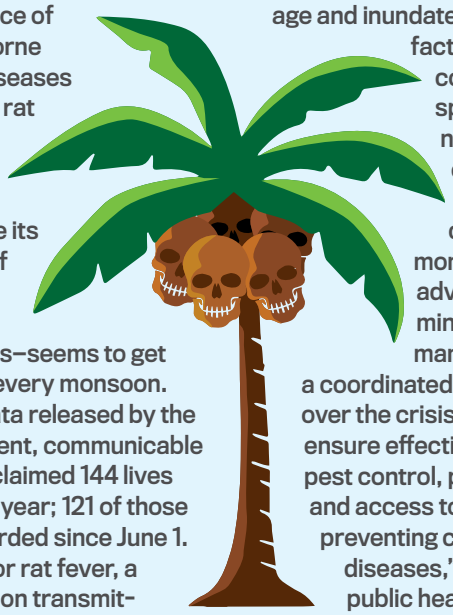


# MALADIES GALORE

By Jeemon Jacob

A 'brain-eating' amoeba, which thrives in warm freshwater bodies, has claimed the lives of three children while infecting at least one more over the past two months in Kerala. All of them, aged between five and 14 years, were diagnosed with primary amoebic meningoencephalitis (PAM), a rare disease spread through the pathogenic *Naegleria fowleri*. The infection destroys brain tissue, causing death in most cases.

Be it the outbreaks of Nipah and Zika viruses in recent years or the high incidence of other vector-borne and zoonotic diseases like dengue and rat fever, Kerala's public healthcare system—despite its wide network of 1,278 government and 2,062 private hospitals—seems to get overstretched every monsoon. According to data released by the health department, communicable diseases have claimed 144 lives till mid-July this year; 121 of those have been recorded since June 1. Leptospirosis, or rat fever, a bacterial infection transmitted by contact with the urine of rodents and farm animals, leads with a death toll of 67. On July 13 alone, 12,204 people with fever were admitted to various government hospitals. Of them, 438 were diagnosed with dengue.



Health minister Veena George acknowledges the gravity of the situation, while claiming the health department is "fully geared" for it. "Normally, the state witnesses a higher incidence of communicable diseases during monsoon. But, this time, more infections are being reported. We have alerted the local bodies to conduct health audits and alert the public," she told INDIA TODAY.

Dengue, spread via the bite of Aedes mosquitoes, surfaced in Kerala in 1998. Once confined to a few districts, it has now spread across the state. Similarly, leptospirosis—listed as a rare disease in the 1980s—has become a major public health hazard in the past decade. "Since 2020, leptospirosis has killed over 1,000 people," says Opposition leader V.D. Satheeshan. "It's a shame for a government that claims to have India's best health management system."

Changes in patterns of land use, polluted rivers, poor drainage and inundated paddy fields—factors that have contributed to the spread of communicable diseases over the past two decades—get accentuated during monsoon. Dr B. Ekbal, advisor to the chief minister on health management, calls for a coordinated action plan to tide over the crisis. "It is essential to ensure effective mosquito and pest control, proper sanitation, and access to clean water for preventing communicable diseases," he says. "Tailored public health measures are necessary to control the recurring diseases." Dr V. Ramankutty, a public health activist, concurs. "Prevention is the best way to check infectious diseases. That's lacking at present," he says. That deficit has disproportionately affected the poor, with their immunity levels seen to be considerably weaker, notes Dr Vinodkumar T.G. Nair, a scientist at the Jawaharlal Nehru Tropical Botanic Garden and Research Institute, Thiruvananthapuram. The state's response to this ever-evolving challenge will be crucial in saving its populace from a disease burden that can overwhelm even Kerala's much-vaunted public health system. ■